

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Medium

CORE FORMULA

Acknowledge their experience -> Make clear you are not agreeing with the claim -> Hold both

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say 'I can see why you feel that way' before 'I don't agree with that.' Both sentences. In that order.

BEST FOR

- Conflict situations where emotions are high
- Feedback that is partly emotional and partly factual
- Responding to distress without conceding accuracy
- Maintaining a position while keeping the relationship intact

PHRASE BANK

Validation Without Agreement · Acknowledging without conceding

- "I can see why that would feel that way."
- "That experience sounds genuinely frustrating — and..."
- "I understand why you are angry, and I still see it differently."
- "Your feeling is real. My read of the situation is different."
- "I hear the concern — I do not share the conclusion."
- "That experience makes sense. The interpretation I would put on it is different."
- "I am not dismissing how that landed — I just do not agree with the claim."
- "Both of those things can be true: that it felt bad, and that I acted correctly."

Holding Both · Keeping validation and your position simultaneously

- "I can hold both of those at once."
- "Your experience is real and I see it differently."
- "I am not saying you are wrong to feel that. I am saying I see it differently."
- "Neither of us is wrong — we are describing different things."
- "The feeling is valid. The conclusion I would draw from it is different."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Dismissing the emotion: 'That is not what happened'
Better: I do not think that is quite right.
Best: I can see why it felt that way — and my read of what happened is different.
- Weak: Agreeing to end the conflict: 'You are right, I was wrong'
Better: I can see why you are frustrated.
Best: Validate the feeling cleanly. Then state your position clearly. Hold both.
- Weak: Validating in a tone that implies sarcasm
Better: I understand.
Best: Genuine acknowledgement of their experience, then a clear, neutral statement of your view.

DECISION TREE

If Someone is upset and making a claim you disagree with

Validate the emotion first. Separate it from the factual claim.

"I can see this is really frustrating. My read of what happened is different."

If They interpret validation as agreement and press harder

Clarify the distinction.

"I want to be clear — I am not saying you are right about X. I am saying I understand why you feel that way."

If Their claim contains truth and error

Validate the true part. Correct only the error.

"The part you have right is X. The part I see differently is Y."

If You validate and they feel dismissed anyway

Ask what they need to feel heard.

"I want to make sure I am hearing you fully — what am I missing?"

SCENARIOS

Direct report feels unfairly treated by a decision

Validate the feeling without conceding the decision was wrong. — "I can see why that landed as unfair — and I stand behind the decision. Let me explain why."

Partner upset about something you did

Acknowledge the impact before defending the intention. — "I can see it hurt — that was not my intention, and I also want to understand why it hit that way."

Client is angry about a service outcome

Validate the frustration before correcting the factual misunderstanding. — "That experience sounds genuinely frustrating. I want to clear up what actually happened."

Colleague says you were unfair in a meeting

Validate that their experience was real before presenting your view. — "I hear that it felt that way. I saw it differently — can I share my perspective?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When validation is impossible to offer genuinely — offering it dishonestly will be detected.
- When urgency means you need to express your view immediately and pausing to validate would delay a critical decision.
- When the person's position is based on factual errors that your validation might inadvertently reinforce.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Separate emotion from claim

In one conversation today, notice when someone's emotion and factual claim are different things. Do not respond yet — just notice.

Day 2 — Validate first

In one disagreement, validate the emotion before saying anything about the facts.

Day 3 — The clean distinction

Practise saying: 'I understand why you feel that way — and I see the situation differently.' In that order.

Day 4 — Hold both

In one conversation, explicitly say that both the feeling and your different view can be true at once.

Day 5 — The hard case

Use this with someone who is very upset and whose factual claim you believe is wrong.

Day 6 — Check for sincerity

After each validation, ask yourself: was that genuine? Or was it a technique to smooth the conversation?

Day 7 — Calibration

Did conversations de-escalate? Did you hold your position? Did any validation feel hollow or manipulative?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I acknowledge their experience before stating my position?
- Did I separate their emotion from their factual claim?
- Was my validation genuine — not a tactic to soften them up?
- Did I still state my position clearly after validating?

- Did I make clear I was validating the feeling, not agreeing with the claim?
- Did the conversation de-escalate?
- Did I hold my position without becoming cold or defensive?